

Who gets to belong in the nation's story, and what happens to the people who do not fit?

I came into this course carrying the Maghreb not as a topic, but as a lived reality. I'm Tunisian. I am gay. I grew up in a country where the law can still treat your private life as a crime, including through Article 230, which criminalizes same sex relations. I learned early that "the nation" is not just a flag or a song. It's also a set of rules about who is allowed to be visible, who must stay quiet, and who gets called dangerous.

That is why so many of the works we read felt personal even when they were written about Algeria or Morocco, or about decades before I was born. They kept returning to one question that I cannot stop thinking about: who gets to speak for the nation, and who is pushed outside the story so the story can stay "clean".

Fanon helps me name what I have felt but could not always explain. In *The Wretched of the Earth*, he warns that after independence, a "national bourgeoisie" can take the place of the colonizer without changing the structures of domination. He also insists that national culture is not a "museum" of authenticity. It's something made in struggle, shaped by the present, and distorted when elites use it as propaganda.

I read Fanon as someone who has watched nationalism become a kind of performance. In Tunisia, you are taught to love the nation. You are also taught what kinds of love don't count. You can be celebrated as "Tunisian" until your identity becomes inconvenient. Then you become a problem to manage. Fanon's writing makes that pattern legible.

He's not only describing postcolonial politics. He is describing the way a nation can ask people to sacrifice parts of themselves in exchange for belonging.

The Battle of Algiers shows power as something practical. It lives in checkpoints, surveillance, raids, and the ordinary routines that divide a city into zones of permission and suspicion. The film depicts the French paratroopers using torture and intimidation as tools of counterinsurgency, and it depicts the FLN using bombings and coercion as tools of insurgency.

What stays with me is the film's lesson about legibility. The colonized body is made readable as dangerous before it speaks. A person becomes a target because the system has learned to see them as a category. I know that feeling. When homosexuality is criminalized, you learn that the state does not really need to know your whole life to punish you. It only needs enough to label you. You learn to move carefully, to carry fear in your posture.

I watched Pontecorvo's city and thought about my own. Not because Tunis is Algiers, but because the logic travels. A state can call itself modern, and still rely on old technologies of control. You start to understand that freedom is not only a political declaration. It's the daily experience of not being hunted by paperwork, rumors, or police.

If *The Battle of Algiers* shows systems, Maïssa Bey shows what systems do to people over time. *Do You Hear in the Mountains* is an autofictional encounter that brings together an Algerian woman and a French man on a train in France, with the Algerian War and its afterlives pressing into their conversation and silence. The plot is simple. The feeling is not. It's about how history sits inside ordinary interactions, how memory is carried in the body, how pain appears through what cannot be said.

This piece made me think about the cost of living with a split self. When you have had to hide your identity, you become skilled at managing what others see. But you pay for that skill. Bey's writing captures that kind of cost. It's not only about past atrocities. It is about what those atrocities do to language. It is about the way trauma can make you quiet even when you want to speak.

Assia Djébar's *Women of Algiers in Their Apartment* adds another nice layer. The collection depicts urban Algerian women who "threw off the shackles of colonialism" only to face a postcolonial regime that denies and subjugates them even as it celebrates men's liberation. Djébar's point is not really abstract. She shows how women's lives are turned into symbols. The nation speaks in a loud voice, but it often does not listen to women's voices inside homes, friendships, and private spaces.

I could not read Djébar without thinking about how the policing of sexuality often rides on the policing of women. Even when the law targets "sodomy," the social order that enforces it depends on controlling women's bodies, reputations, and futures. Djébar's writing made me notice how the national "we" is built through exclusions that are treated

as normal. It also made me notice how survival often depends on creating small rooms of truth, spaces where people can speak without being punished.

Papicha brings that struggle into the 1990s Algerian “Black Decade,” following a young university student in Algiers who dreams of becoming a fashion designer and organizes a fashion show as defiance amid rising fundamentalism. The film is not subtle about danger, but its deepest argument is quiet. Joy is political. Friendship is political. Style is political. When violence tries to control your body, a dress can become a refusal.

I found *Papicha* painful because it shows how quickly life can narrow. One day you are a student with plans. The next day you are calculating risk in every hallway. That shift is familiar to anyone who has lived under a system that can criminalize you. You learn that the fight is not only for rights on paper. It is for the ability to live without constant self editing.

Abdellah Taïa’s *Salvation Army* is openly autobiographical, telling the story of a young Moroccan man coming into being as a gay man within a society that shuns him. Taïa does something that feels both simple and radical. He refuses to let queerness be only a scandal or a political slogan. He writes it as a life, with all its contradictions, tenderness, and risk.

For me, Taïa is one of the most direct answers to the question of belonging. The nation can insist it’s unified. The nation can insist it’s moral. But Taïa shows how that “unity” can demand silence from people whose lives do not really fit the public script. His work also makes something else clear. The personal is never only personal in the Maghreb.

Intimacy is political because it's monitored. Love is political because it is punished.
Speech is political because it can expose you.

If I had to turn all of this into one statement, it would be this: the nation is an argument about who counts. Independence does not end that argument. Sometimes it intensifies it.

Fanon warns that postcolonial power can reproduce colonial structures. Pontecorvo shows how systems of control train people's bodies and habits. Bey shows how memory makes ordinary life heavy. Djebbar shows how women's lives are erased even when liberation is celebrated. *Papicha* shows how resistance can look like refusing to surrender joy. Taïa shows what it costs to write the truth of a queer life in a society that wants that life to stay unnamed.

And my own story sits underneath all of it. When you grow up in Tunisia as a gay person, you learn that opportunity is never just personal talent. It's also the space a system gives you to breathe. When that space shrinks, survival becomes about strategy. You learn to read power. You learn to anticipate danger. You learn what it means when a state says "we" and you are not really sure you are even included.

This course has not given me a single answer, and I don't think it should. It has given me a clearer way to see. It has shown me that literature and film are not decorations around history. They are places where people fight to be recognized as fully human. They are counter archives when official archives lie. Most of all, these works remind me of something I want to keep close. A nation can criminalize your body, but it can't fully erase your voice unless you give it permission. Fanon, Djébar, Bey, Taïa, and even the women of *Papicha* all refuse that permission in different ways. Their refusal is not always loud. Sometimes it's simply the decision to speak anyway.